DOXYLAMINE + PYRIDOXINE

Pregnancy: first-line

Drowsiness

CHEMICAL NAME Doxylamine succinate: N,N-dimethyl-2-[1-phenyl-1-(pyridin-2-yl)ethoxy]ethanamine + pyridoxine hydrochloride (vitamin B6)

CLASS Antihistamine + vitamin B6 combination antiemetic for pregnancy

TRADE NAMES Diclegis · Xonvea · Diclectin · Bonjesta

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Nausea and vomiting of pregnancy not responding to dietary measures.

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** delayed-release tablets on an empty stomach with water; swallow whole.
- Regular schedule (at bedtime ± morning and afternoon), not as needed.

DOSAGES

- **Delayed-release (10 mg/10 mg):** 2 tablets at bedtime on day 1.
- If needed, add 1 tablet in the morning (day 3), then 1 mid-afternoon — max 4 tablets/day.
- Extended-release (20/20 mg): 1 at bedtime, may increase to 2/day.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** delayed (enteric coating) — 5–7 h. Food delays absorption further.
- Doxylamine metabolised in liver; pyridoxine converted to pyridoxal-5-phosphate.
- **t½:** doxylamine ~12 h.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Doxylamine: **H1 antagonist** with anticholinergic, antiemetic and sedative effects.
- Pyridoxine: mechanism unclear; deficiency linked with nausea.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Drowsiness (common).
- Dizziness, dry mouth.
- Headache, constipation.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Anticholinergic effects: urinary retention, blurred vision.
- Excessive sedation with CNS depressants.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Hypersensitivity to doxylamine, ethanolamine antihistamines or pyridoxine.
- MAOI use.
- **Caution:** asthma, glaucoma, peptic ulcer obstruction, urinary retention.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Alcohol, sedatives, opioids:** ↑ sedation.
- **MAOIs:** prolonged anticholinergic effects.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Assess severity of nausea/vomiting, weight, ketones, hydration.
- Escalate to IV fluids/other antiemetics if hyperemesis.
- Advise on sedation.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Take on an empty stomach at bedtime; swallow whole.
- Avoid driving if drowsy.
- Small frequent meals, ginger, avoid triggers.
- Seek help if unable to keep fluids down.

KEY POINTS

- First-line drug for nausea of pregnancy.
- Drowsiness.
- 2 tablets at bedtime, max 4/day.
- Regular dosing on empty stomach.